

# Giving instructions on the phone

COMMUNICATION

LEVEL  
Upper-intermediate

NUMBER  
EN\_BE\_3506X

LANGUAGE  
English

lingoda





## Goals

- Can understand useful structures for giving clear instructions
- Can use new words and phrases to give clear instructions while remaining polite





**The main goal of our project is to** make communication between departments easier. **First of all**, we want to have a consultation with each individual department. **In this part you can either give** feedback by email or we can arrange for a one-on-one meeting in your department. **Does that all make sense?**



## Speaking on the phone

**Do you often speak on the phone at work? What kinds of things do you often have to deal with on the phone?**



clients

colleagues

suppliers

making  
arrangements



## Giving instructions

When was the last time you had to give someone instructions on how to do something? Maybe you had to help someone assemble a piece of furniture, use an IT program, or file a special report at work? Tell your teacher about it!





## Giving instructions

**Read the quote below from someone who hates giving instructions. Do you agree with the speaker? Why or why not? What do you think is important to remember when giving someone instructions?**

“

If someone needs a lot of help, I think they're lazy. People need to use their own initiative. I hate giving instructions – find it out for yourself I say! I often have to help people, only to find the problem is something a quick internet search could have resolved.

”

## Giving instructions

When giving instructions it's important to be **clear** and to **make sure** that **everyone** is on the **same page** from the start.

The best way to do this is to take time to **break** the task **down** into **steps** and introduce each step **clearly** and **simply**.

In the next few slides, you will learn some new phrases to help you with this.



**The only thing we need to focus on is** getting this project finished by the deadline. The **first thing we need to do** is this...



## New phrases for introducing instructions

The main goal of our project is to

The main goal of our project is to establish a network for entrepreneurs so they can share tips and resources.



I am going to tell you how to

I am going to tell you how to start your own business.



You will need the following

You will need the following: patience, determination and a solid business plan.



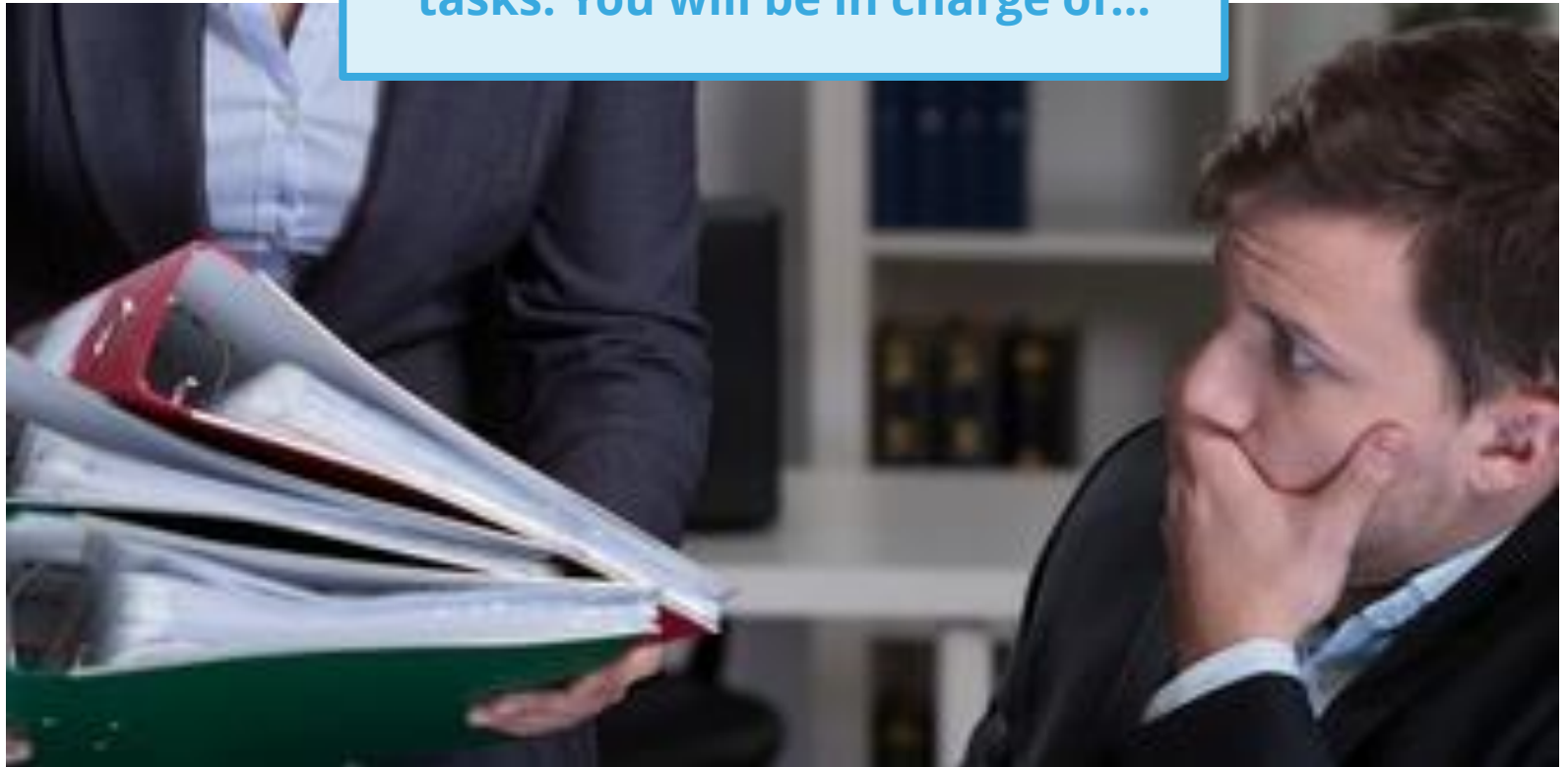
We need someone who can... since we will...

We need someone who can design websites since we will publish our results online.





We will need to divide up the tasks. You will be in charge of...



We need to divide up the tasks. You will be in charge of doing the reports, Michael.



## Practise introducing instructions

**Look at the situations on the cards below. Use the new phrases from the previous slides to give introductions to the instructions to come on each card.**

A friend is baking  
their first ever  
birthday cake

A new colleague is  
giving their first  
presentation about  
a new project

Together with a  
friend, you are  
launching your own  
business

You and a colleague  
are working on a big  
project at work, there  
are a lot of tasks to be  
done



## Real life examples

Think of 3 different examples from home or work where you might need to give instructions.





## Role play

Take one of the three situations you thought of in the previous activity and build it into a role play on the phone. Use as many of the phrases you have learnt for using on the phone as possible. Practise introducing the tasks, using the new phrases from the previous slides where you can.



Hi! Is that \_\_\_\_\_?

...



...

## Sequencing the instructions

As well as making sure your instructions are **clear**, be sure to introduce all the steps in **sequence**. This is very important for communicating over the phone as it can be **confusing** if you **miss** out **crucial steps** and try to add them later, so try to avoid doing this.

Look at the examples of instructions below. Which do you think is better **sequenced**?



Oh, it'll be fine, just go into the hallway and check for the car key on the desk. Oh, wait, no! **Firstly** you have to disarm the house alarm...oh dear...too late...



This is quite straightforward, but **I'll talk you through it slowly. First things first:** are you on a web browser at your computer? Okay. Go to the website [marketwizard.com](http://marketwizard.com). I want you to...



## New phrases for sequencing instructions

**First of all...**

**First of all** draw up a solid business plan, remember to do your research.



**Next...**

**Next**, consult with your bank to try to get a loan.



**After that...**

**After that** you need to get in touch with your customer base. Advertising is key.



**Finally...**

**Finally**, remember to keep up-to-date with your accounts, it will make doing your taxes a lot easier!



This is the part where you need  
to...



This is the part where **you need to** network. Talk to everyone and give out  
your business cards!



## Writing a recipe book

You are a top chef and you are organising a team of two friends (Laura and Albert) to write a recipe booklet for charity with your favourite 4 recipes.

Can you give Laura and Albert instructions for how to write the booklet using the new phrases you have learnt?







## Practise sequencing instructions

**Look at the situations on the cards below. What would the sequence of instructions be in each case? Would any of these situations be explained over the phone, do you think?**

How to set up a  
business bank  
account

How to look for a  
new job

How to send an  
email

How to make a  
phone call to set  
up a meeting  
with a client



## Focusing on details

- As well as making sure your instructions are clear and in sequence, remember to focus on any **important details** so that whoever you are giving instructions to **knows what is** especially **important**.
- Remember that you are the person with the **knowledge** of what to do: it's up to you to **communicate** this **effectively**!

- **The most important thing to remember** is to be clear and concise. **Don't let** your team get bogged down in the smaller details. We are on a serious time constraint. Make sure you **emphasise** that.





## New phrases for focusing on details

When you do this, be careful (not) to...

When you do this be **careful to** save your work as you go!



You do it like this...

Changing the printer cartridge is easy, and **you do it like this.**



In this part you can either do ... or ...

**In this part you can either** do a short summary of your activity so far **or** you can upload the latest activity report.



Here there is the risk of...

**Here there is a risk of** data theft so be careful and ensure you only use verified sites to make the bookings.





## Double checking instructions

- In English, **double checking** something is a synonym for **making sure** of something.
- When giving instructions over the phone, it is especially important to **double check** that you have given **correct instructions** and also that they have been **fully understood**.



One good way to double check if someone has understood instructions is to ask if they can **repeat the instructions back to you!**



## New phrases for double checking instructions

Is everything clear?

Some of the language is quite complicated, **is everything clear?**



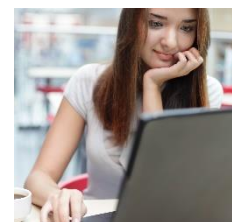
Did I go too fast?

I know it's a lot to take in, **did I go too fast?**



Should I repeat this part?

**Should I repeat this part?** It's the most difficult.

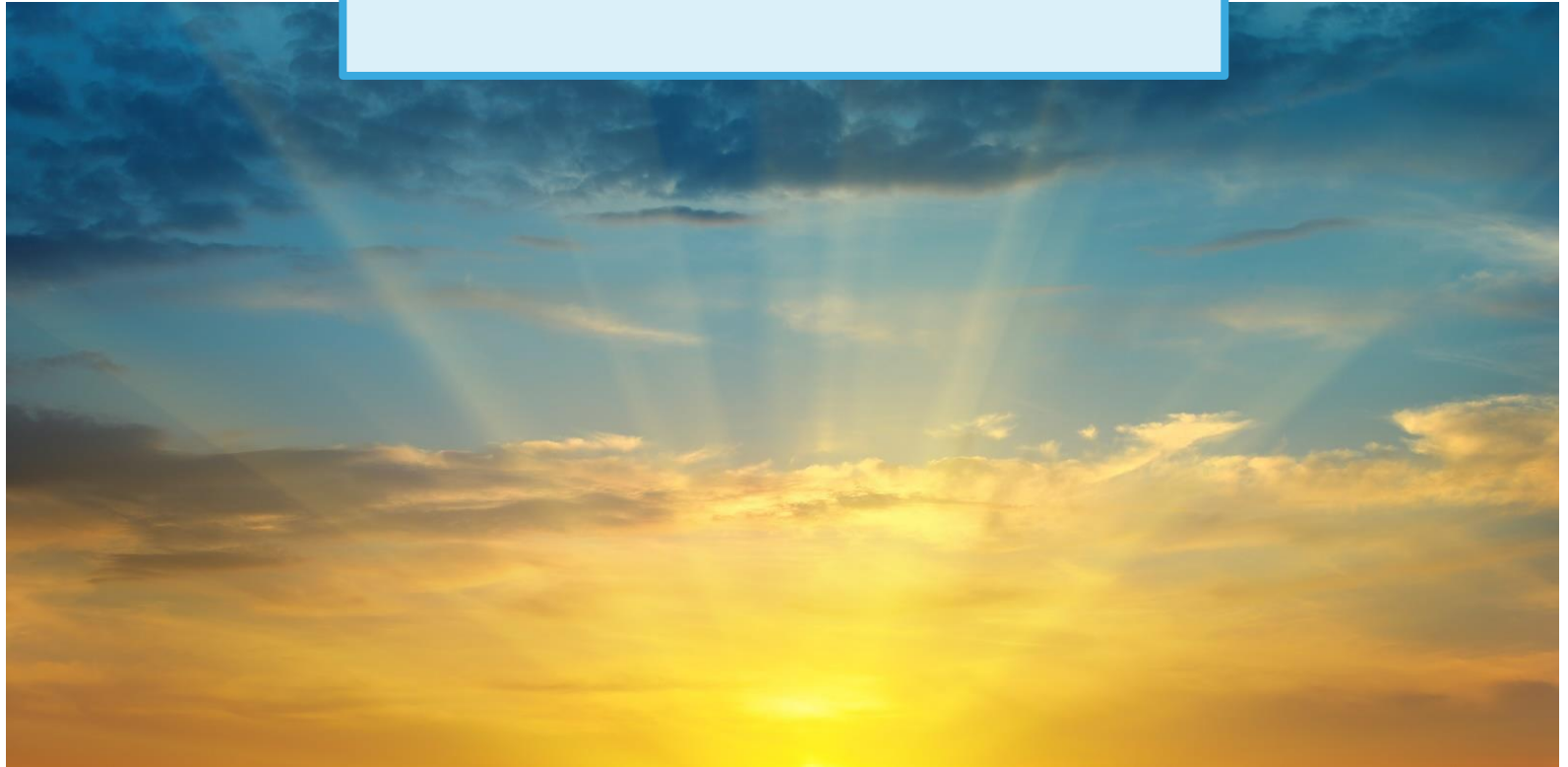


Did you understand everything?

How did the conference call go? **Did you understand everything?**



Does that make sense?



We use the expression **does that (all) make sense** colloquially to double check that something is clear and has been understood.



## Instructions on the phone

**Read the set of instructions below given by a boss to his employee, Darren. What do you notice about the way the instructions are given?**



Hi Darren! Thanks for returning my call so quickly. The reason I rang is that we really need to make hiring our biggest priority for this quarter. We are low on staff and it's starting to have negative effects on the company.

So, the first thing I need you to do is put out job adverts – everywhere! Any website you can think of. If we don't get enough replies, we may need to go to a recruitment agency as a last resort.

Next, clear your schedule next week for back-to-back interviews. Be careful to balance your work, as it's most important to screen CVs and reply to applicants as promptly as possible.

Did I go too fast? Do you have any questions?



## Moving office

**Your office is moving premises, but you, the office manager, are away on a business trip. Give instructions to Stefan, your colleague who is filling in for you, over the phone. Tell him what needs to be moved first, what belongs to the old premises and what should be taken to the new office.**

fragile objects  
and valuables

furniture

packing

directions





## Phone and organise a birthday surprise

**You are organising a surprise birthday party for a friend (Lucy) and you need to organise and phone 5 more friends (Lauren, Julian, Maria, Mario and James) to do the shopping, to decorate, (but only after Lucy has left for work), to cook, to set the table, to delay Lucy with a good excuse and to clean up the mess after the party. Who does what at which point? Remember to tell them to be careful with the furniture in the house, not to lose the keys, to clean under the sofa and not to spend more than €60 when shopping.**





## Putting everything into practice

**Now think of 3 situations, at work where you might have to give instructions. Practise giving these instructions to your teacher in full and make sure to use as much of the vocabulary from the class as possible. Check the example on page 23 if you need help.**



introduction

sequence

details

double check

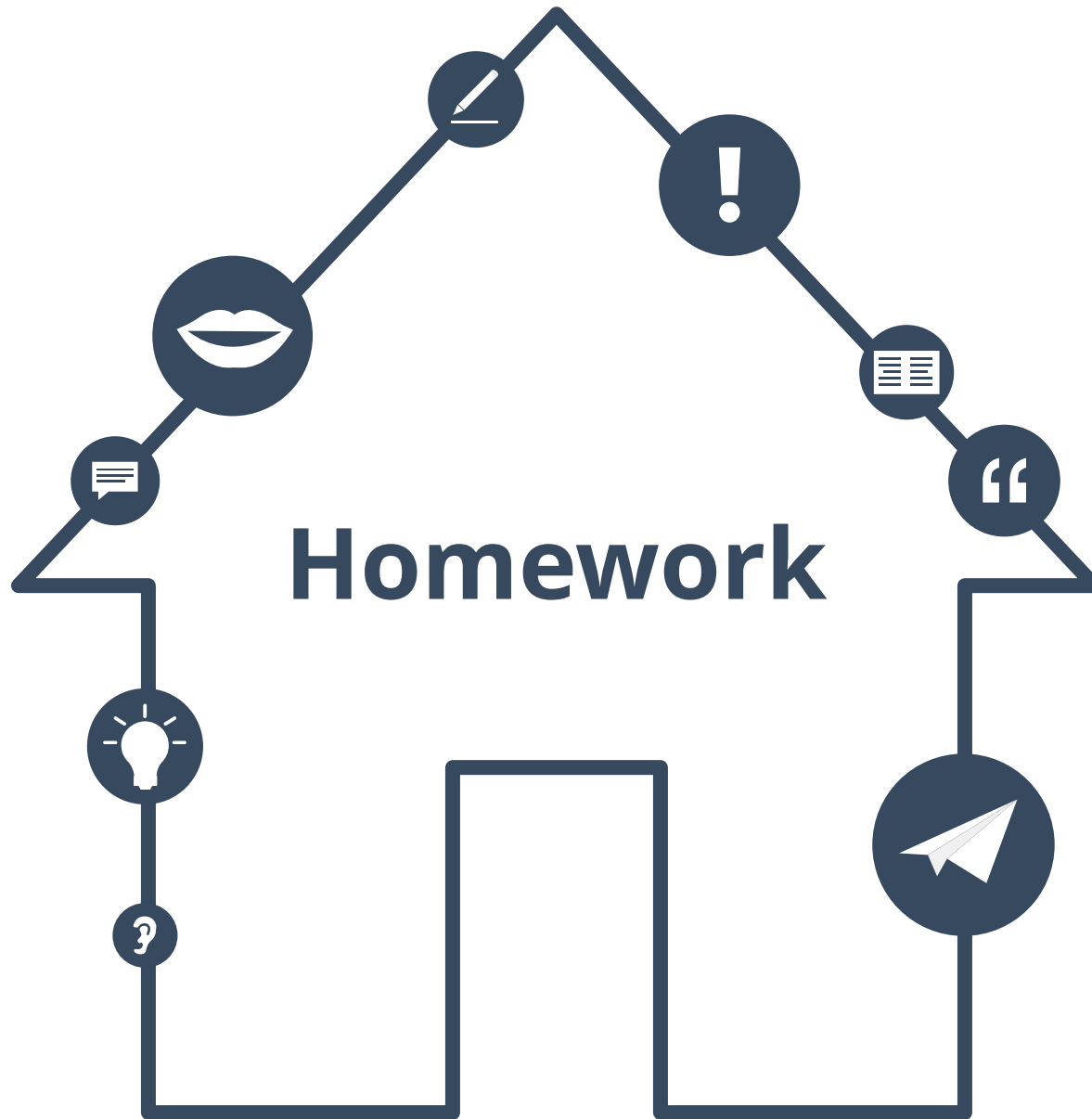


## Reflect on the lesson

Take a moment to review any new **vocabulary, phrases, language structures** or **grammar points** you have come across for the first time in this lesson.

Review them with your teacher one more time to make sure you don't forget!







## Reflect on the lesson

**How did you find this class? Which parts did you find most challenging? Which did you find easiest?**

A vertical sheet of white paper with a spiral binding on the left side and horizontal lines for writing.



## Instructions in practice

**Think about your current role. What kind of things might you need to instruct clients or colleagues on? Choose an example and write a sample phone conversation giving instructions to someone. Try to incorporate new vocabulary from the lesson.**

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